Florida College

Martin Luther and His View on Baptism

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Joshua M. Haub
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Martin Luther and His View on Baptism

Martin Luther is a central figure in the foundation of the Reformation beginning in the 16th century. It was his work and resolve to teach what he believed was the truth that led many to leave the Catholic church and exercise their faith independently. It is, therefore, understandable that his teaching on topics such as justification, faith, baptism, and others, have significant weight in Protestant theology. However Martin Luther has not always been properly understood. His translation of Romans 3:28 featuring *sola fide* (faith only) is often taken to mean acts of obedience such as baptism are unnecessary. This is not what he believed or taught. Martin Luther, despite his *sola fide* translation of Romans 3:28, believed baptism was ordinarily necessary for salvation.

Martin Luther Misunderstood

Martin Luther is a complex theologian, and his views are often misunderstood. There is no exception to his view on baptism. Many Protestant preachers and laymen have taken his *sola fide* translation of Romans 3:28 and created a dogma centered around the teaching that states, essentially, that baptism is "not required" for salvation. Luther, in his letter "Ein Sendbrief vom Dolmetschen" (An Open Letter on Translating), explains why he inserted the word *sola* into the verse: (1) he wanted to create a translation that was easy to read in German, reflecting the way his language was used in his day, and (2) "the text itself and St Paul's meaning positively demand and require it."[1] He goes on to say, "St Paul so entirely excludes works that he even says that the works of the law – God's law and God's word, in fact – do not help us to justification."[2]

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[1] M. Luther, *Ein Sendbrief vom Dolmetschen (An Open Letter on Translating)*, trans. Howard Jones (Oxford: Taylor Institution Library, 2017), 29. For the full discussion, see pp. 5-35.
[2] Ibid.

He, therefore, firmly believed that there is *no human work* that we could do to save ourselves; it was totally and completely Jesus and His blood.[3]

However, Luther also talked about the importance of baptism countless times.[4] Two of his most predominate works on the subject are found in his two works: *The Large Catechism* (April 1529) and *The Small Catechism* (April 1529), respectively. In his *Large Catechism* he says,

> Here stand God's commandment and institution, lest we doubt that Baptism is divine, not devised nor invented by men…Baptism is no human trifle, but instituted by God Himself, moreover, that it is the most solemnly and strictly commanded that we must be baptized or we cannot be saved…we esteem Baptism excellent…*for which we contend and fight chiefly*, because the world is now so full of sects clamoring that Baptism is an external thing, and that external things are of no benefit.[5]

In Luther's *Small Catechism* (April 1529), he says:

> Baptism is not only simple water, but it is the water comprehended in God's commandment and united with God's word. … It effects the remission of sins, frees us from death and the devil, and gives blessedness everlasting to those who believe what the word and the promise of God declare. …the word of God, which is with and on the water [gives these benefits], and the faith which believes such

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[3] Ibid., 33.

[4] Luther preferred *full immersions* for baptisms. Luther says, "I wish that those to be baptised were entirely sunken in the water; not that I think it necessary, but that of so perfect and complete a thing, there should be also an equally complete and perfect sign," as qtd. in H. Jacobs and C. Jacobs, "A Treatise on the Holy Sacrament of Baptism 1519," in *Works of Martin Luther with Introductions and Notes* (Philadelphia: A. J. Holman Company, 1915), 51. The authors go on to clarify that the immersion that Luther was speaking of was infant baptism, not adult baptism.

[5] M. Luther, *The Large Catechism*, Christian Classics Ethereal Library, https://www.ccel.org/ccel/luther/largecatechism.html, 79. Italics added.

> word of God in the water. … It signifies that the old Adam in us is to be drowned by daily repentance and penance, and is to die, with all sins and evil desires, and that daily is to arise and emerge a new man, who is to live before God in righteousness and purity for ever.[6]

So which is it? Is baptism required or is it by faith alone? Here lies the difficulty with understanding Martin Luther and his view on baptism. How can it be that he says one must be baptized *and* that one is saved by faith alone? D. Ramsey notes that some see baptism and faith only as "two separate issues" and are not contradictory.[7] However, some, such as R. C. Sproul, believe they are contradictory.[8] Ramsey ultimately argues that they are contradictory, stating that "Luther's doctrine of baptism is inconsistent with his doctrine of justification by faith alone" even though Luther himself believed they were in harmony.[9]

Martin Luther: Baptism, Faith, and Salvation

How did Luther harmonize these two beliefs? First, Luther believed in pedobaptism (infant baptism), and this may have been the "default" type of baptism he discussed.[10] Luther distinguished between infant and adult baptism and what occurs at

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[6] M. Luther, *Luther's Primary Works: Together with His Shorter and Larger Catechisms*, ed. and trans. Henry Wace and C. A. Buchheim (London: Hodder and Stoughton, 1896), 13–4.
[7] D. Ramsey, "Sola Fide Compromised? Martin Luther and the Doctrine of Baptism," *Themelios* 34, no. 2 (2009): 180. Ramsey goes on to note: "Anthony Lane… not[es] that *sola fide*, as understood by Luther and the other Reformers, was directed against works but not word or sacrament." To Luther, baptism is a *sacrament* and therefore it seems that he viewed it as being in a different category from "works" in the sense of "earning" salvation, however it can become this if one is not careful. This was Luther's critique of Catholics' view of baptism when he wrote "If a sacrament were to give me grace just because I receive that sacrament, then surely I should obtain the grace, not by faith, but by my works." See M. Luther as qtd. in ibid., 186. Sometimes, however, Luther does call faith (and maybe baptism) a "work," see quotation in footnote 21.
[8] Ibid.
[9] Ibid.
[10] C. Cortright, "Luther on Infant Baptism: 'On Rebaptism' (1528) and 'Large Catechism' (1529)," *Religion. Church. Society*, no. VII (2018): 91. Cortright goes on to say: "It is not the age of the baptizand, nor his faith that is

these different baptisms. Before discussing his views on infant baptism, it is worth noting his specific beliefs about salvation. First, Luther believed that one needed to be baptized because it is a command from God.[11] He also believed one needed to have faith.[12] However, he distinguished between the *effects* of baptism and the *validity* of it. The validity, Luther argues, comes from the fact that it is a command from God.[13] No matter if someone has faith or not, a baptism is a baptism. A person is obeying God by being baptized, whether faith is involved in their decision or not. This is a work of God and therefore not a "human work."[14] Luther states, "baptism, too, is a work of God…"[15] When one is baptized, he or she is simply obeying God. However, his or her baptism needs faith for the baptism to result in true salvation.[16] This faith "comes from hearing His [God's] Word."[17] "Baptism is valid because it is God's act, but faith is required 'for enjoying the benefits of the promise.'"[18] Thus, a person could be baptized without having faith. However, it is not until they put their faith in God and the baptism that it results in salvation.[19] "[Luther] claimed that, 'It is not baptism that justifies or benefits anyone, but it is faith in that word of promise to which baptism is added. This faith justifies, and

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the core concern of Luther's theology, but <<the water enclosed in God's command and connected with God's Word>> (SC, Baptism, 1-2)." For a discussion on Martin Luther and infant baptism, see p. 70-92.

[11] See M. Luther, *The Large Catechism*, 79.

[12] So F. Gayoba, "Martin Luther's Understanding of Faith in Relation to Infant Baptism," *Andrews University Seminary Studies* 58, no. 1 (2020), 66. He writes that for "Martin Luther, baptism is 'indissolubly bound with faith.'"

[13] Ibid., 65. See also M. Luther, *The Large Catechism*, 79.

[14] C. Cortright, "Luther on Infant Baptism," 79.

[15] Ibid.

[16] The term used in C. Cortright and F. Gayoba is "fruit." I have interpreted this to mean "salvation."

[17] F. Gayoba, "Martin Luther's Understanding of Faith," 70.

[18] Ibid., 75.

[19] Connected with this, Luther states, "It is not the Sacrament [baptism], but faith in the Sacrament, which justifies. …Thus it was evidently not the sacrifice of Abel which justified him, but the faith by which he offered himself entirely to God, of which faith the outward sacrifice was a figure." See M. Luther, *Luther's Primary Works*, 348-9.

fulfills that which baptism signifies.'"[20] Faith and baptism work hand-in-hand, but faith is the most important part which God gives to people through His word.[21,22] Faith, like baptism, is the working of God.[23] Therefore, one needs to have faith and be baptized to receive salvation; however, neither are "human works" because both are from God's doing.

To further the point, Luther says in his *Treatise on Baptism* (1519):

> So we find that through sin baptism is, indeed, hindered in its work…yet only by unbelief in its operation is baptism brought to naught. Faith, in turn, removes the hindrance to the operation of baptism. So much depends on faith. …The forgiveness of sins is obtained by faith… both the forgiveness and the driving out of sins are the work of baptism. …For so long as I believe that God is willing not to count my sins against me, my baptism is in force and my sins are forgiven, though they may still, in a great measure, remain.[24]

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[20] F. Gayoba, "Martin Luther's Understanding of Faith," 67. The author is citing Luther in his work M. Luther, *Luther's Primary Works*, 349. Luther goes on to say, "Now the sacraments are not fulfilled by being done, but by being believed."

[21] So Luther in M. Luther, *Luther's Primary Works*, 350: "Let us understand that wherever there is a Divine promise, there faith is required, and that both of these are so necessary that neither can be of any effect without the other. We can neither believe unless we have a promise, nor is the promise effectual unless it is believed; while if these two act reciprocally, they produce a real and sure efficacy in the sacraments." Also, Luther said, "If you would be saved, you must begin with the faith of the sacraments, without any works whatever; but on faith the works will follow: only do not think lightly of faith, which is a work, and of all works the most excellent and the most difficult to do. Through it alone you will be saved, even if you should be compelled to do without any other works. For it is a work of God, not of man, as Paul teaches. The other works He works through us and with our help, but this one He works in us without our help." See T. W. Albert Steinhaeuser, "A Prelude on the Babylonian Captivity of the Church," in *Works of Martin Luther with Introductions and Notes* (Philadelphia: A. J. Holman Company, 1916), 224.

[22] Luther believed that baptism was "ordinary required for salvation." Ramsey notes that when Luther wrote "in 1520 against the medieval tradition, Luther willingly acknowledges that one can be saved apart from the sacrament, though not apart from faith." See D. Ramsey, "Sola Fide Compromised?" 189.

[23] See F. Gayoba, "Martin Luther's Understanding of Faith," 70. Gayoba notes on Luther's view of predestination and God's sovereignty, "It is up to God to produce faith in those whom He chooses." See ibid., 71.

[24] H. Jacobs and C. Jacobs, "A Treatise on the Holy Sacrament of Baptism 1519," 65–6.

However, there is an issue for Luther. If one needs faith (which comes from God and His word) to be saved, how could he uphold pedobaptism? Firstly, Luther believed in Original Sin.[25] Therefore, children needed salvation from the moment they are born. He also believed that when infants are baptized, God gives them faith.[26] This giving of faith allows children to be saved just like adults. In connection with his belief in infant baptism, he believed that baptism could even create faith in a child.[27] Luther also argued that the belief of others, and their prayers, could result in the infant receiving the faith needed for salvation.[28] Therefore, a child's baptism could be both *valid* and *effective* all because God is at work.

Luther also notes that in baptism, a person chooses to die to sin and dedicate oneself to spending the rest of his or her life eliminating sin from his or her life (with the help of God's grace and Holy Spirit).[29] It is because of this new covenant made in baptism that one is constantly forgiven even when one sins.[30]

Luther also believed that a Christian could lose his or her salvation.[31] "We see then how rich a Christian, or baptised man, is, since, even if he would, he cannot lose his salvation by any sins however great, *unless he refuses to believe*; for no sins whatever can condemn him *but unbelief alone*."[32] To regain salvation, a person did not need to be

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[25] So ibid., 57.
[26] C. Cortright, "Luther on Infant Baptism," 75. Cortright says, "[Luther] affirms the faith of infants, not as their decision or by proxy, but as the gracious working of the Holy Spirit through the divine word <<in and with the water>> of Holy Baptism."
[27] D. Ramsey, "Sola Fide Compromised?" 183.
[28] M. Luther, *Luther's Primary Works*, 357. He goes on to state that even the faith of others, accompanied by prayer, could result in salvation when a wicked adult participated in "any of the sacraments" (of which baptism is one).
[29] H. Jacobs and C. Jacobs, "A Treatise on the Holy Sacrament of Baptism 1519," 61.
[30] Ibid.
[31] M. Luther, *Luther's Primary Works*, 343. Italics added.
[32] Ibid.

rebaptized. Instead, they needed to begin to believe again. If they did, then "All their sins…are swallowed up in a moment through that same faith."[33]

Martin Luther and "Heretics"

Another key to understanding Luther is to understand that Luther's writings are often in reaction to what he believed to be false teaching, such as Catholics (earlier in life) and Anabaptists (later in life). Gayoba notes that Luther put "emphasis on faith in baptism against Roman Catholicism and…de-emphasis on faith against Anabaptism."[34]

With Catholics, Luther fought against the tendency to turn "the sacraments into empty rituals devoid of faith."[35] Luther said, "It is not baptism that justifies or benefits anyone, but it is faith in that word of promise to which baptism is added. This faith justifies, and fulfills that which baptism signifies."[36] "The younger Luther clearly saw faith as necessary for baptism."[37]

With Anabaptists, however, he fought against the belief that faith was required before one is baptized, a stance that would have resulted in the consequence that infants could not be baptized (because they are unable to have faith).[38] Luther argued that one could not know if someone really has faith or not and therefore making faith a prerequisite for baptism is, essentially, meaningless.[39] He also stated that infant baptism is "the most certain form of baptism" because infants are unable to "fake" belief in order

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[33] Ibid.
[34] F. Gayoba, "Martin Luther's Understanding of Faith," 65.
[35] Ibid., 67. For a full critique of the Pope and the Catholic Church, see M. Luther, *Luther's Primary Works*, 353-65.
[36] M. Luther as qtd. in ibid.
[37] Ibid.
[38] Ibid., 68.
[39] Ibid. Luther says, "'Even if you baptize a person a hundred times a day, you would not at all know if he believes,' and therefore, 'neither the baptizer nor the baptized can base baptism on a certain faith.'"

to deceive others.[40] "Thus, according to an older Luther, faith should not be a prerequisite for baptism."[41]

Analysis

Martin Luther is one of the most influential people from the Protestant Reformation. His willingness to stand up for what he believed is admirable and millions are indebted to him and his teaching (along with his contemporaries). However it is important to remember that Luther was not always correct. His decision to translate Romans 3:28 as *sola fide* and refusal to change it despite its controversy has created misunderstanding among many Protestant groups who are unlearned in Lutheran theology.[42] Luther believed he was teaching what Paul meant but the confusion has led to many groups doing exactly what Luther condemned when he wrote "It is pure wickedness and blasphemy of the devil that now our new spirits, to mock at Baptism, omit from it God's Word and institution."[43]

Not only has Luther's translation caused confusion, but his belief in infant baptism is also puzzling. Gayoba states, "[Luther] assumed biblical support for infant baptism and searched for arguments to prove it. His biblical references look more like proof texts than a thorough biblical treatise" and "It appears that Luther's support for infant baptism was largely influenced by tradition and the writings of Augustine, even

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[40] M. Luther as qtd. in ibid.
[41] Ibid.
[42] M. Luther, *Ein Sendbrief vom Dolmetschen,* 17. Luther states, "I was fully aware that the word 'solum' doesn't occur in the Latin or Greek text and didn't need the papists to teach me that…the donkey-heads are gawping at ['solum'] like cows at a new gate." Also, "It's going to stay in my New Testament, and even if every donkey in popedom goes berserk, I'm not letting them take it away." See p. 35.
[43] M. Luther, *The Large Catechism*, 80.

though he publicly affirmed *sola Scriptura*."[44] For a man who was attempting to lead the Church back to the truth of Scripture, even he was not wholly absolved of tradition and bias.

What is worse than misunderstanding Luther is misunderstanding Paul who, in Romans 3:28, did not write *sola fide*![45] While Luther himself believed that baptism is an essential part of the process of salvation, Protestants who have come after him do not, but cite Luther's *sola fide* as the source of their doctrine of "Faith Only."[46] Those who cite *sola fide* are citing Luther's understanding of Paul instead of Paul himself. This misunderstanding of Luther and Paul must be corrected. Paul speaks of *obedient* faith twice in Romans (1:5, 16:26) and baptism (Chapter 6). A failure to recognize the significance of these passages in Romans has led many to outright reject baptism despite Paul, Acts, Peter, and other NT writings and examples that teach the contrary.

Luther, despite his Romans 3:28 translation and adherence to infant baptism, was correct in his view that baptism was necessary for salvation. D. Ramsey connects Luther with the Restoration Movement, saying, "The necessity of baptism for justification is by no means a belief of a bygone era…It is advocated today, sometimes quite strenuously…Those with the loudest voice belong to what is sometimes called 'The Restoration Movement,' and are associated with the Christian Church and the Church of Christ."[47]

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[44] F. Gayoba, "Martin Luther's Understanding," 79 and 80. Gayoba footnotes a statement from Luther: "No book except the Bible and St. Augustine has come to my attention from which I have learned more about God, Christ, man and all things."
[45] For this point, I am indebted to Scott Smelser, "Faith Only: Misunderstanding Martin Luther and Paul," Bible Class, Indiana Bible Camp, 2022.
[46] R. C. Sproul interprets "the *sola fide* formula as directed against baptism." See D. Ramsey, "Sola Fide Compromised?" 180.
[47] Ibid., 192.

Conclusion

Martin Luther, despite his *sola fide* translation of Romans 3:28, believed baptism was ordinarily necessary for salvation. This is not the end of the discussion of Martin Luther and his view of baptism. There are many more points to be made. However, for now, it is essential to remember that if one wants to understand Paul, read Paul. It is important to always return to Scripture as the source for doctrine rather than church leaders. If one is not careful, he or she will fall into the same trap as Luther did with infant baptism, using Scripture to prooftext his or her doctrine rather than living by what the text actually says.

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